



IN HIS COMEBACK SEASON AFTER KNEE SURGERY, SREESHANKAR, FRESH FROM AN 8.05M LEAP IN PUNE LAST MONTH, DAZZLED AT HIS FAVOURITE VENUE, NEARING 8M THREE TIMES BEFORE CLINCHING HIS SEASON-BEST LEAP ON HIS FINAL ATTEMPT

Ranasinghe (80.65m) took first and third places respectively. Both secured automatic Worlds qualification, underlining the growing dominance of South East Asian throwers, alongside Olympic champion Arshad Nadeem and World champion Neeraj Chopra.

Among the Indians, Shivam Lokhare (80.73m) claimed second place, while Rohit Yadav, Asian Championships silver medallist Sachin Yadav (PB 85.16m in May) and Yashvir Singh finished fourth, fifth and sixth with 80.35m, 79.80m and 78.53m respectively.

The Ramaraj sisters endured disappointment. Vithya was disqualified for a false start in the 400m, while Nithya, leading comfortably in the 100m hurdles, stumbled at the eighth hurdle, fell, and fractured her leg.

Sreeshankar, who trained at the Kalinga Stadium for about a week, leapt close to 8m three times before summoning his remaining energy to better his season best with a winning effort of 8.13m. He will be aiming to improve that by another 14cm at the Inter-State Championships in Chennai to secure a Worlds berth.

Notably, national record holder Jeswin Aldrin did not start.

In the women's long jump, Shaili Singh (6.28m) fell short of her season best of 6.64m.

Kujur, who set national records in the 100m (10.18) and 200m (20.32) this season and spent six weeks training and competing in Europe, found it difficult to acclimatise to the hot, humid home conditions after developing cold-like symptoms on his return.

Training at the venue, Kujur withdrew midway through the 100m heats in the morning to focus on the 200m. The Asian Championships bronze medallist clocked 20.99 in the heats before overcoming Korean Ko Seunghwan in the final, regaining the lead in the last 30m to claim victory in 20.77, cheered on by a vocal crowd.

"The European exposure was new for both me and my coach. We are learning. I wanted to perform close to my personal best, but this is okay.